There is doctrinal variety, as well. Those Hindus who are steeped in the *Upanishads* and the *Bhagavad Gita*, suffused with a sense of Brahman (the Ultimate Reality underlying all phenomena) pervading the cosmos and debating its unity with atman (the Universal Soul also present in each of us) would consider themselves monotheists; the 'common man', innocent of such texts, might think of the multiple deities he sees around him as different gods, and have no difficulty with being considered a polytheist. The truth is that it doesn't matter. These are all equally valid ways of being a Hindu.

This pervasive multiplicity of practices and beliefs makes it difficult to conceptualise Hinduism as one might other religions. As a term of description, indeed, 'Hindu' implies no monolithic identity; to speak of the 'Hindu community' as one might the 'Muslim ummah' is contestable, since Muslims are bound to each other by credos, convictions and rules of which Hindus are innocent. The absence of standard practices and belief systems, and the absence of ecclesiastical hierarchies and universal religious institutions, adds to the difficulty. When Christians disagree amongst each other, they disagree with reference to the interpretation of one single book, the Bible, whose teachings remain the fountainhead of their faith. The same is true of Muslims, though the room for interpretation is less, since the Quran is seen as the revealed word of God, though the Hadith offers more room for discussion. Hinduism has no such handy volume; when Hindus seek guidance, it is rarely to textual authority that they turn (though often to spiritual guides or gurus, whose knowledge, at least in theory, may be derived from their understanding of various scriptures).

In recent times, the *Bhagavad Gita* has become the equivalent of a 'sacred book' for the Hindus, due to its frequent use by twentieth-century gurus such as Swami Chinmayananda and political leaders like Mahatma Gandhi. The *Gita* subsumes the ideals of the Vedas and Upanishads in the words of the popular deity Krishna, and its exhortation to do one's duty irrespective of the consequences has been cited as an inspiration by various figures on the world stage, from Turkish Prime Minister Bulent Ecevit to justify his country's invasion of Cyprus, to my failed candidacy for the Secretary-Generalship of the United Nations.